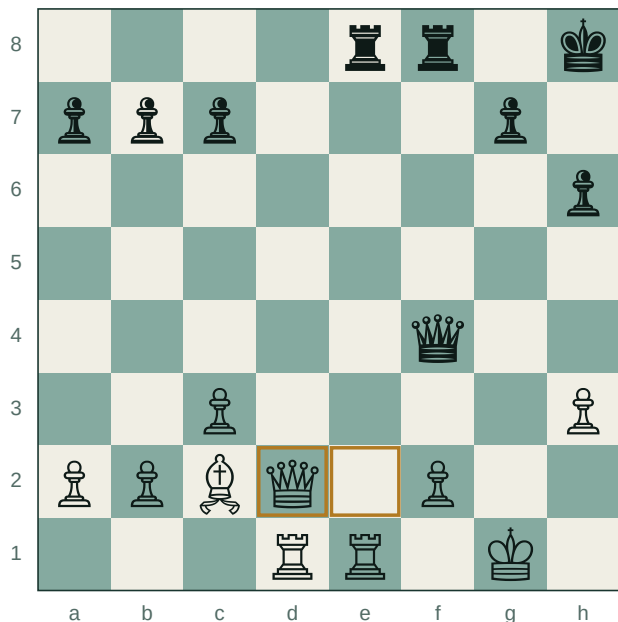


Capture the defender: Black, move 27

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 27.Qd2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

27...Qxd2 28. Rxd2 Rxe1+

27...Qxd2 The queen captures the queen on d2. From d2 it attacks rook on e1, rook on d1 and bishop on c2. Recorded reply: **28.Rxd2**.

28...Rxe1+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on e1.

At the end, nominal material is White 13 / Black 15 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +5:** the balance goes from -3 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.